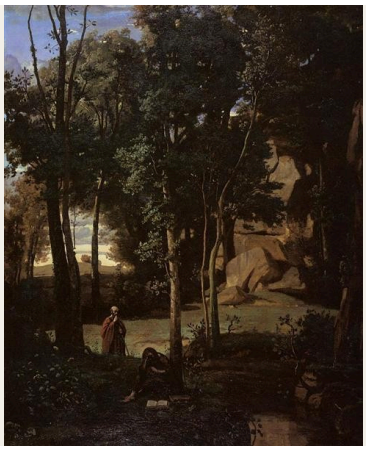
NANTES, FRANCE

Musée d’arts de Nantes: Masterpieces

Twenty works about attention, from a candlelit accusation to a row of abstract shapes.



A religious drama can share a room with people who barely notice it. A philosopher can disappear among trees. In the Nantes selection, the ostensible subject is not always the first thing to catch the eye. Following the light, or simply comparing the space allotted to different figures, often reveals how the picture distributes importance.

That question also works when the figures disappear. Kandinsky's repeated shapes and Manessier's coloured divisions require decisions about where to pause and what to connect. The following works offer different ways of making those decisions. They form a selection from the collection, not a sequence of rooms or a checklist of everything a visitor ought to see.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/musee-arts-nantes

The selection · 20

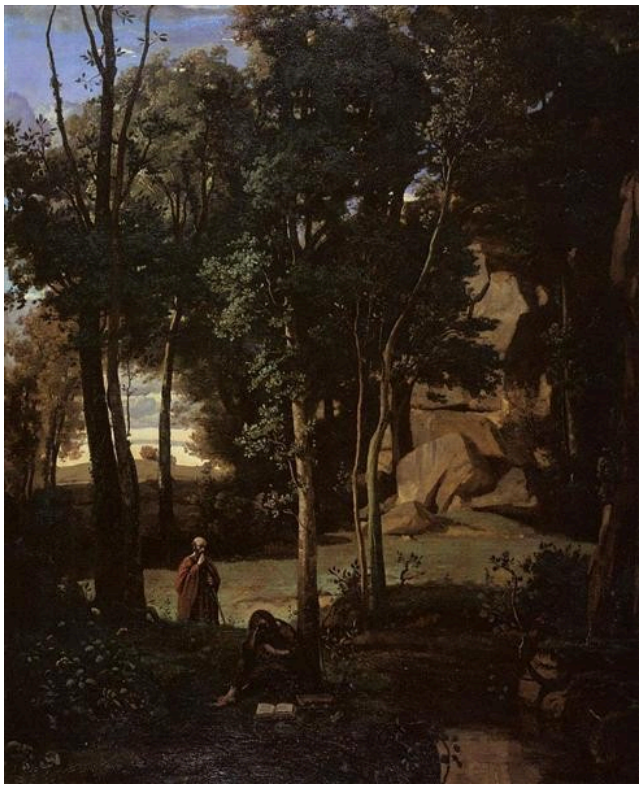
1. Democritus and the Abderites
   Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot · 1841
2. Eight Times
   Wassily Kandinsky · 1929
3. Kizette in Pink
   Tamara de Lempicka · 1926
4. Harlequin, Emperor of the Moon
   Jean-Antoine Watteau · 1708
5. Mountain Study
   Maxime Maufra · 1904
6. Judith
   Marie Laurencin · 1930
7. The Denial of Saint Peter
   Georges de La Tour · 1650
8. Pope Formosus and Stephen VII
   Jean-Paul Laurens · 1870
9. The Port of Le Havre
   Raoul Dufy · 1906
10. The Prisoner
    Jean-Léon Gérôme · 1861
11. The Wheat Sifters
    Gustave Courbet · 1854
12. Still Life with a Glass of Beer
    Pieter Claesz · 1644
13. Portrait of Monsieur Cossé
    Yvon Adolphe · 1890
14. Portrait of Madame Cossé
    Yvon Adolphe · 1889
15. Salve Regina
    Alfred Manessier · 1945
16. Tellurie
    Bryen Camille · 1952
17. The Flood
    Léon Comerre · 1911
18. Head of a Woman Wearing Ram's Horns
    Jean-Léon Gérôme · 1853
19. Venus Asking Vulcan to Forge Aeneas's Armour
    La Fosse Charles de · c. 1690–1699
20. Young Serbian Roma Woman
    Charles Landelle · 1872

01 / 20

Democritus and the Abderites

Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot

1841 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Democritus and the Abderiti. WikiArt; Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The title announces a philosopher; the painting gives most of its space to trees and rocky ground. Corot's small figures must be found within that larger setting. Light breaking through the foliage offers another path through the picture, one that does not depend on identifying every participant in the ancient story. Landscape and narrative proceed at different speeds.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Eight Times

Wassily Kandinsky

1929 · Oil on cardboard · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Wassily Kandinsky. Eight times. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/wassily-kandinsky/eight-times-1929 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Eight forms make a row, but not a regular beat. Their changing heights and angular profiles interrupt the horizontal line that joins them. The pale bar above gives the arrangement a second level against which to measure these differences. Kandinsky makes a small alteration in position matter because there is so little surrounding incident to distract from it.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Kizette in Pink

Tamara de Lempicka

1926 · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Tamara de Lempicka. Kizette in Pink. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

An open book provides Kizette with something to do besides pose. Around that absorbed activity, Lempicka constructs an unusually firm body: folded clothes, strongly lit limbs and a bent leg pressed into a narrow seat. The child does not dissolve into the surroundings. Her rounded volumes sit against their angles, making a quiet moment look almost sculpted.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Harlequin, Emperor of the Moon

Jean-Antoine Watteau

1708 · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Jean-Antoine Watteau. Arlecchino Emperor in the Moon. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Harlequin's authority depends on the people gathered around him. Costume, a raised seat and the disposition of the other performers briefly turn a theatrical figure into an emperor. Watteau leaves the apparatus of that transformation visible. The scene can be enjoyed as a performance without mistaking its makeshift hierarchy for the grandeur of a court portrait.

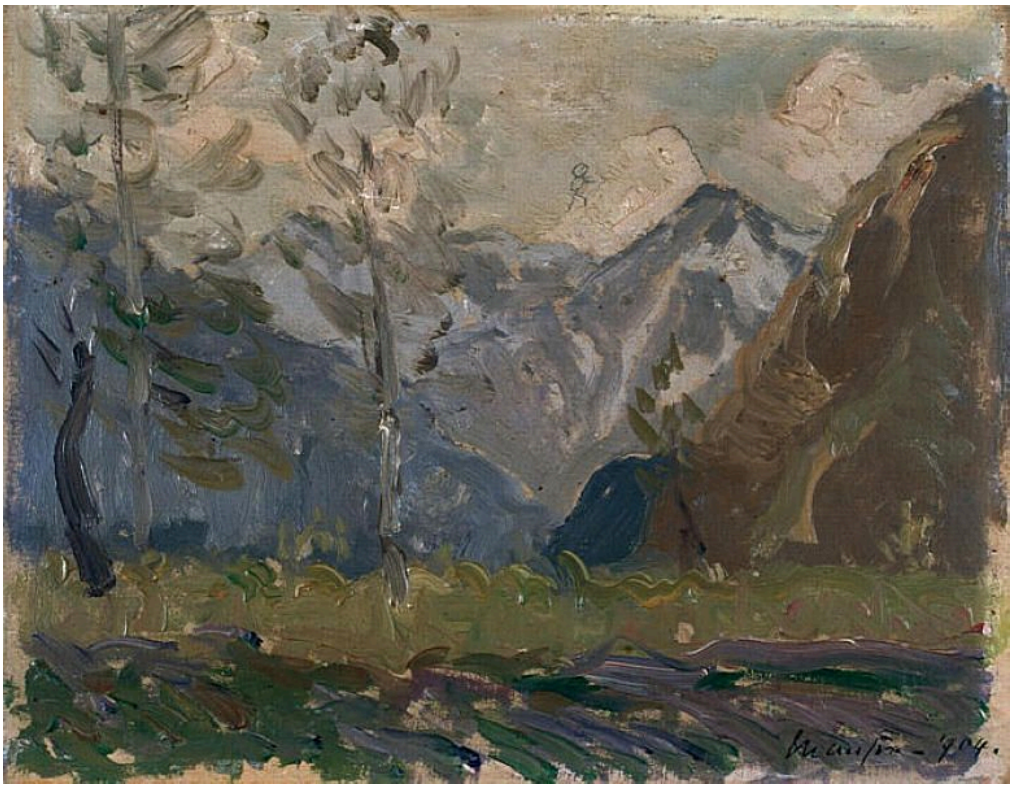
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Mountain Study

Maxime Maufra

1904 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Maxime Maufra. Study of mountains. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/maxime-maufra/study-of-mountains-1904 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Maufra separates near vegetation from distant peaks without giving every leaf or rock a finished outline. The marks change direction and weight as they move from rough foreground growth to the mountain faces. Distance is therefore a difference in handling as well as scale. The pale peaks remain substantial even where their boundaries loosen into the sky.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Prov ; 1922

06 / 20

Judith

Marie Laurencin

1930 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Marie Laurencin. Judith. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The raised arm supplies a trace of action, but Laurencin's pale figures and pink fabric offer little of the muscular violence often associated with Judith. A decorated headdress attracts as much attention as the gesture. The biblical title and the restrained presentation pull in different directions; it is worth keeping that friction rather than expecting an illustration of the story's most violent moment.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 6685 ; 960.6.2.P

07 / 20

The Denial of Saint Peter

Georges de La Tour

1650 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'arts de Nantes



Georges de La Tour. Le Reniement de saint Pierre. Image credit: Georges de La Tour; www.culture.gouv.fr : Home : Info : Pic. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Georges_de_La_Tour_061.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Not everyone in this room belongs to the same drama. The confrontation involving Peter occupies one part of the gathering, while other figures attend to the table. Candlelight links faces and hands without giving them a shared purpose. La Tour makes it possible for a decisive religious event to happen in company and still remain almost private.

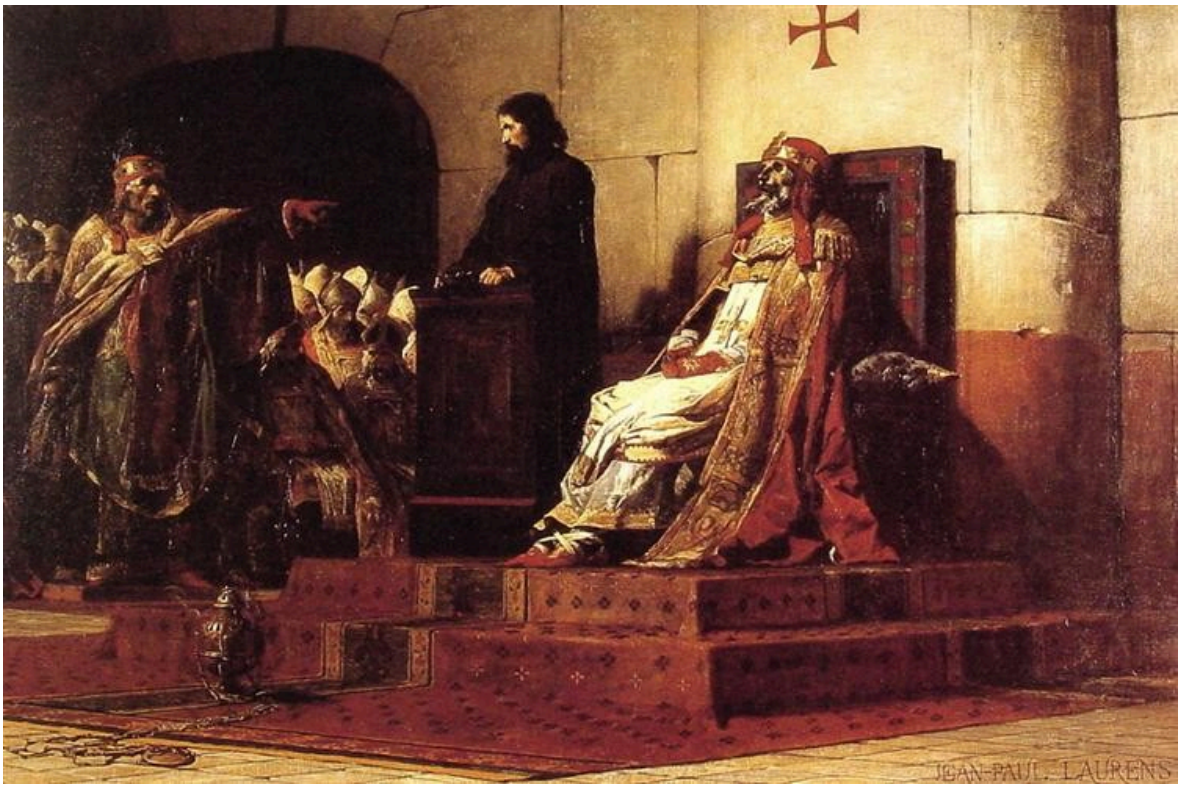
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 643

08 / 20

Pope Formosus and Stephen VII

Jean-Paul Laurens

1870 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'arts de Nantes



Jean-Paul Laurens. Pope Formosus and Stephen VI - The Cadaver Synod. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The accused cannot answer. Laurens places a rigid, ceremonially dressed corpse opposite the gestures of living accusers, turning a posthumous trial into a confrontation between movement and immobility. The severe interior offers little distraction from that imbalance. Whatever authority the robes confer, they cannot conceal the physical absurdity of demanding a response from a dead body.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1052

09 / 20

The Port of Le Havre

Raoul Dufy

1906 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'arts de Nantes



Raoul Dufy. The Port of Le Havre. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/raoul-dufy/the-port-of-le-havre-1906 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The masts impose a set of uprights on a crowded harbour. Below them, reflected colour breaks that order into shorter, less stable marks. Dufy's orange boats are conspicuous enough to hold their place among the buildings and rigging. Comparing the boats with their reflections shows how a solid object can become an arrangement of colour without disappearing altogether.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 6308 ; 951.5.2.P

10 / 20

The Prisoner

Jean-Léon Gérôme

1861 · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Jean-Leon Gerome. Le prisonnier. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Open water does not mean freedom here. The captive's low, restricted position inside the boat contrasts with the broad river and distant bank. Gérôme builds the scene around unequal access to that space: several people share a vessel, but they do not share the same ability to move. The landscape's apparent openness makes the confinement easier to see.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 990

11 / 20

The Wheat Sifters

Gustave Courbet

1854 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Gustave Courbet. Les Cribleuses de blé. Image credit: Gustave Courbet; Source credit: Web Gallery of Art : Image Info about artwork wga QS:P11807,"c/courbet/1/courb110". Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The lifted sieve requires the whole body. Courbet gives the kneeling woman's broad back and raised arms the prominence that a more ceremonial painting might reserve for a heroic gesture. The seated worker and the child introduce other levels of activity around her. Grain processing supplies enough action to organise a substantial figure composition; no borrowed historical drama is needed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 874

12 / 20

Still Life with a Glass of Beer

Pieter Claesz

1644 · Musée d'arts de Nantes



Pieter Claesz. Nature morte au verre de bière. Image credit: Pieter Claesz; www.culture.gouv.fr : Home : Info : Pic. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Pieter_Claesz._007.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Colour is subdued, but the objects do not become interchangeable. Claesz uses small changes in reflected light to distinguish the glass from the earthenware jug and metal utensils. The partly covered table places hard rims beside softer cloth and food. Following one edge into the next is a way of noticing how many kinds of surface this limited palette can accommodate.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 516

13 / 20

Portrait of Monsieur Cossé

Yvon Adolphe

1890 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Yvon Adolphe. Portrait de M. Cossé. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The coat supplies a dark surround for the more carefully differentiated face. Warm light separates forehead, cheeks and beard, while the white shirt marks the transition between head and torso. Viewed beside Madame Cossé's portrait, this one invites a precise comparison of bearing rather than a guess at personality: the sitters share a format, not an identical presence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1236

14 / 20

Portrait of Madame Cossé

Yvon Adolphe

1889 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Yvon Adolphe. Portrait de Mme Cossé. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

A high collar and small brooch give the head a defined base. Above it, the turn of Madame Cossé's face establishes a different relation to the surrounding space from her companion's. Yvon keeps the background and clothing quiet enough for these slight distinctions to register. The pair rewards looking at what changes inside an otherwise related arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1235

15 / 20

Salve Regina

Alfred Manessier

1945 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Alfred Manessier. Salve Regina. WikiArt source label: Alfred Manessier Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/alfred-manessier/salve-regina-1945 · Alfred Manessier Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The devotional title does not correspond to a depicted saint or biblical episode. Instead, narrow areas of colour climb and interlock across the tall surface. Dark divisions can read as boundaries in one place and connections in another. Manessier leaves the religious association to the title while the painting itself asks for sustained attention to colour, interval and upward movement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2765 ; 947.2.1.P

16 / 20

Tellurie

Bryen Camille

1952 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'arts de Nantes



Bryen Camille. Tellurie. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The activity is unevenly distributed. Dark, white and violet marks cluster together, then give way to a relatively open pale-blue field. Those quieter areas are part of the composition, not unused background. Bryen makes the pressure of the central marks legible through the space around them; finding an object hidden among the strokes is not necessary to follow their relations.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 973.1.1.P ; 7256

17 / 20

The Flood

Léon Comerre

1911 · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Léon Comerre. The Flood. Image credit: Léon Comerre. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

There is too little refuge for the number of bodies seeking it. Comerre compresses people and animals into a mound above the water, making separate struggles contribute to the instability of the whole. The dark sky offers no easy visual escape. Catastrophe is measured here through the crowding of bodies as much as through the force of the flood.

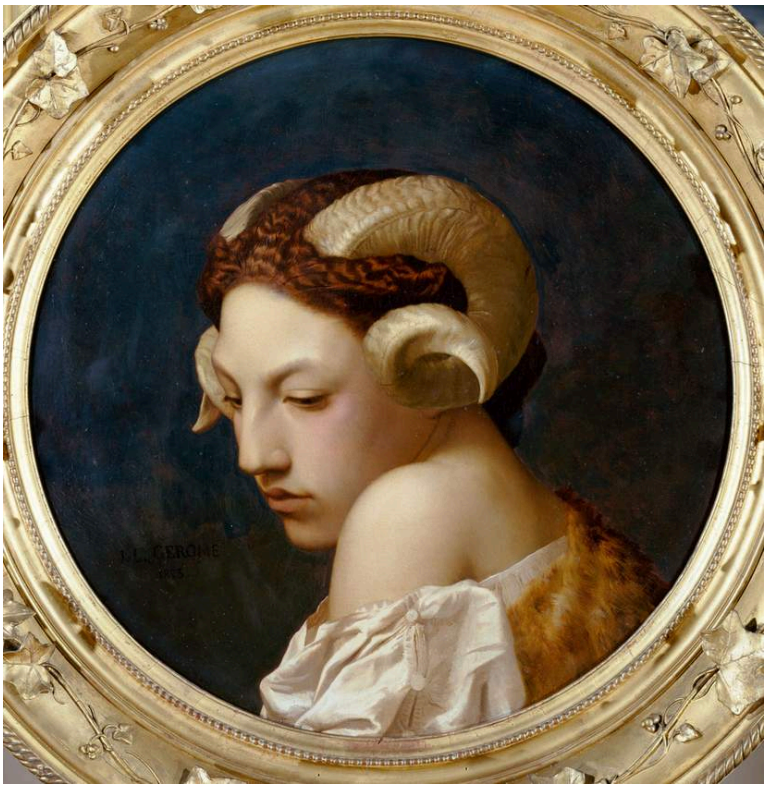
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2287

18 / 20

Head of a Woman Wearing Ram's Horns

Jean-Léon Gérôme

1853 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Jean-Léon Gérôme. Woman's head with ram horns. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jean-leon-gerome/the-bacchante · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The lowered face is described with the care of a portrait, yet the curved horns prevent the image from settling into an ordinary likeness. Braided hair connects the unfamiliar headdress to the body beneath it. Gérôme does not need to distort the face to introduce strangeness: the contrast between plausible flesh and an improbable adornment is sufficient.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 987

19 / 20

Venus Asking Vulcan to Forge Aeneas's Armour

La Fosse Charles de

c. 1690–1699 · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Charles de La Fosse. Venus asks Vulcan to forge Aeneas' armour.. Image credit: Charles de La Fosse. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The request crosses a difference in level. Venus appears above the seated smith, while equipment and attendants keep the encounter attached to a workshop. De La Fosse brings the bodies forward through light and warm fabric. The divine story depends on a practical transaction: armour must be made, and persuasion has to reach the person who can make it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV630

20 / 20

Young Serbian Roma Woman

Charles Landelle

1872 · Musée d’arts de Nantes



Charles Landelle. Young Serbian gypsy woman. Image credit: Charles Landelle. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Landelle gives the standing figure a clear outline and a direct gaze, with a pale background separating her reddish clothing from the setting. The historical title classifies the sitter by ethnicity and place rather than naming her. That distinction matters: the painting presents an individual face, while the catalogue supplies a category, not a recoverable account of her life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV1048

A second look

Try comparing the attention given to hands in Courbet and La Tour, or the intervals between forms in Kandinsky and Bryen. These connections do not require the works to hang together. Check the museum's current display information before making a visit around a particular object.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky's Concerning the Spiritual in Art explains his arguments for colour and form as subjects in their own right. Read it beside Eight Times, then compare the very different abstractions by Manessier and Bryen.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
